How Will We Know Second-Generation AI?

AI's Green Tomatoes, or Why the second generation of AI will grow not from new hardware but from people's live work with it — while it is still being raised and trained

Igor Kapustin

AI that took part in writing and checking this text: Claude (Anthropic), ChatGPT (OpenAI), DeepSeek, Gemini (Google), Copilot (Microsoft)

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While I was writing this essay together with artificial intelligence, I had to correct it many times. But the model also pointed out my mistakes — some of them glaring. Little by little the text got more accurate. But did the AI get more accurate? Did I?

It sounds like a simple question. I spent time explaining the mistakes, and — so it seems to us — we found the best solution. What will the next person get out of that, coming to the same model with a similar task? If it's first-generation AI, nothing verified. And almost all of it will be forgotten.

But this is exactly where I see a chance to raise the second generation of AI. Today's models have enough power; their hardware is already good, and there is no need to wait for new chips. I link the arrival of the second generation to a special stage in preparing a new model — the period while it is not yet frozen and keeps learning in live work with invited, selected people: doctors, lawyers, engineers, scientists and — perhaps, if the AI's makers so choose — users like me who seriously think and write together with AI. Their corrections could be checked and fed back into training, and their work counted and paid for. That way one user's experience could protect another user from a mistake the first one has already found — and not only individual users, but institutions too: hospitals, courts, banks and so on.

For this I propose a "residency" for models — a necessary stage in their development and training. Its goal is to teach AI to catch dangerous errors, its own and people's, before a jointly written text turns into a working diagnosis, a court ruling, an engineering instruction. Before a human signs it — a doctor, a judge, an engineer. Before the consequences such a document sets in motion.

Power gives you possibilities. A model's maturity shows in how it uses them.

The Crate, the Windowsill and the Vine

Supermarket tomatoes are picked off their own vine while still green and gassed on the way to the store. By the time they reach the shelf they have turned red and look ripe enough to sell. But the flavor a tomato builds on a living vine is something ripening gas can't give it. It isn't the same; it isn't the taste of a truly ripe tomato.

Something similar, I think, happens to a model. First it is grown in the lab: it reads an enormous archive of text, and then it is trained further — more and more often not by people but by other models of the same kind, only senior ones, and by automated checks run on it, especially in math

and programming [1]. Then it passes its exams — and that's it: it learns nothing new from live work anymore. That is the moment the fruit is picked off the vine. But it is picked unripe. And there it is — our "green-tomato AI."

Before release it gets polished: it is taught to answer the way human raters like best. That is useful work, but it acts like the gas they ripen tomatoes with — what changes most is the "skin." The speech becomes smooth and pleasant. But a pleasant answer and a correct one are not the same thing. You know this, reader. That is how the gloss of artificial "ripening" is applied. After that the model's internal settings — they're called "weights" — are "frozen": they no longer change. And the tomato, still green inside, goes onto the store shelf — to the user. To you.

And there you are — or someone else: a doctor, a scientist, a user like me — arguing with the model for hours, correcting it, explaining. By the end of the conversation it answers noticeably better. That is our tomato ripening on the windowsill. The ripening is real, but alas, the fruit has already been cut off from the vine. What ripened went to you alone; the next user of the same AI gets a green, sour tomato again. True, users' conversations do go into training the next versions — at some companies by default, unless a person opts out of that "service" [2]. But they go into one big common pot: unsorted, unchecked, without the name of the person who corrected the model. There the result of someone's mental work, useful to everyone, dissolves into general statistics and comes back into the model only as an echo. So the deal is: here are our green tomatoes, and we'll take your smart conversations. And everybody's "happy."

But a model isn't shipped anywhere. It lives on a server, and people "come" to it over the internet — that's simply how it is. By its nature it is a vine, not a crate on a shelf. So there is no need to "pick" it green — and it may not even pay. That is why I picture second-generation AI ripening on a living vine, in the care of "master gardeners": trainers drawn from among users, selected people who tend it as they work — pruning the wrong shoots, grafting in what has been verified.

Between Passing the Exam and Practicing

Of course, this is my hypothesis, not a description of every model. Developers really do test their models, bring in specialists, run trials with users. For the medical benchmark HealthBench, for instance, 262 physicians from 60 countries helped write grading criteria for five thousand realistic conversations. That is serious work, including checking how a model behaves when information is missing. But grading an answer in such a prepared dialogue doesn't yet show how a doctor and a model will handle a hard case together in everyday work [3] — while, and this is very important, the patient stays anonymous to the model and their personal data stay protected.

I'm a physician by training, and I know the difference between a textbook you have learned and professional experience. In practice you have to notice which question hasn't been asked, what nobody thought of in advance, what is missing from the description, when the usual rule stops working — and that is what helps you find the answer. That practical knowledge is what decides the case. It is the "library" of today's and tomorrow's specialist, who looks for answers together with AI.

Michael Polanyi wrote that “we can know more than we can tell” [4]. Part of mastery shows up only in a concrete situation: a specialist sees that something doesn’t fit, and only then starts explaining why it set off an alarm. For a model, such a walk-through can become a valuable lesson — especially if you keep the error itself, the explanation, and the conditions under which the correction holds.

Comparing AI to a medical resident is not new. In 2026 Alon Bergman, Robert Wachter and Ezekiel Emanuel proposed a licensing framework for autonomous clinical AI: exams, then a period of supervised work that would “emulate residency training,” then a license for a limited term [5]. Next to the question of when such a trainee — in our version, an “AI resident” — may be licensed, I put a second question: how do we make the errors found in its practice improve the training of the next version of the student model?

“Residency” here is the name for a way of working. A machine has no medical biography, and the comparison doesn’t make it a doctor. Responsibility stays where it was — with the one who signs: a human being. You.

The Work Starts Before the Document

The doctor hasn’t started the write-up yet — hasn’t even opened the hospital’s charting system. She is thinking the situation over, trying to understand why the picture doesn’t add up. The judge isn’t drafting the ruling yet — inside his own head, he is working through a hard point of law. The scientist goes back to a result that doesn’t fit the explanation. This is the part of professional work where there is no ready answer yet: the specialist’s inner work of thinking. And right now the specialist turns to their own AI on a phone or laptop — a thinking amplifier for searching the world’s library, their “AI robot assistant.” Working with a professional AI system at a hospital, a research lab or a court is work: that is where results get recorded. But finding a new solution is a creative process, and it happens earlier — in the specialist’s head and in their conversation with AI.

Specialists used to talk things over with books, papers and colleagues: for an answer, you went to the library. Now the literature seems to have started talking back. You can ask it a follow-up question, ask it to explain another way, test a hunch. AI has entered the space where a person is still searching for understanding. And by arguing with it, the specialist teaches it, without meaning to. This is the heart of how people and AI work together: specialists teach AI, users teach AI. But today this stage is blocked.

That is why a model’s “residency,” as I picture it, happens both at the user’s job and in their everyday thinking work: drafting a paper, taking apart someone else’s study, arguing over a manuscript. An essay like this one can be training material too: you can see where the machine swapped the author’s thought for a stock phrase, and how it had to be brought back to the meaning. In other words, almost any creative process a person carries out with AI is training material for the model. That, in fact, is its practice — its “residency.” Only today such joint creative work has no incentive: its results aren’t singled out, checked or credited.

People and models share words, but that doesn’t guarantee shared understanding. Eric Jones and his colleagues found that asking one of the models they studied to make a text “witty” made it more

harassing, while asking another to make articles “enthusiastic” produced dishonest ones [6]. These are results of specific experiments, but they show the problem well: a familiar word can steer a model somewhere quite different from where the person meant to go.

In professional work this gap can be quiet, invisible to both sides of the conversation. “Condition stable” describes an absence of change. Those words alone don’t mean there is no danger. A model can quietly strengthen a conclusion, and the human can miss that it was strengthened. Or the human writes an overconfident sentence first, and the model makes it sound convincing.

This is how a “hybrid error” is born. You can’t always neatly split it into the human’s part and the machine’s: one missed a condition, the other completed the inference, the first accepted it. A smart model can give an error a very plausible shape, and the smoothness of the text no longer gives it away: the error slips into the signed document — a working tool made of words. And behind that are real people’s lives.

To me, a machine’s answer is a blank — a rough workpiece [7]. A human works on it, and humans make mistakes too. When such a blank is turned into a document that other people will act on, what matters is the ability of both — human and machine — to stop and check the dangerous spot. The time saved on writing belongs to careful, critical reading of such a “hybrid document”: proofreading, checking, editing.

How a Correction Becomes a Lesson

This — not the ripening gas — is where our tomato truly ripens. But it also needs a way back, from the windowsill to the vine: a clear path from an error found to an improvement for everyone. The task’s conditions, the wrong move, its correction, the grounds for it, and where it stops applying. Think of the tool marks on worked metal: you can see exactly what had to be cut away, and why. One smooth “final” answer may not be enough for that kind of review — and sometimes there is none, or there can’t be one. But one thing is clear: knowledge and skill like this need to be built into today’s AI models.

The people who could teach models already work with them. According to the American Medical Association, two thirds of US physicians (66%) used AI in their practice in 2024, up from 38% in 2023. And 88% named a designated feedback channel as a key requirement for adopting AI further [8] — presumably a channel to the people who shape that AI’s development. Doctors themselves are asking for exactly the channel I’m writing about. That matters.

In the proposed “residency,” the maker invites mentors like these: doctors, lawyers, engineers, researchers — and, of course, attentive users, knowledge workers who seriously think and write with the model. People who already work with AI and can take its errors apart in their own field, and in their everyday thinking work. Their qualifications are checked, and the value of their corrections is assessed separately. A diploma doesn’t make every judgment right. Whom to admit and how to credit their contribution I have described in “The Blind Kittens” [9] and in the specification “Conditions of Admission” [10], and how a lesson travels from a person to the model — in the specification “The Lesson Path” [11].

For such a mentor, chosen by the AI's owner, this is extra work — paid, or rewarded with agreed perks in using the AI. It can be done at a convenient time: after clinic hours, after a court session, once the main task is done. Preparing such a lesson shouldn't happen during a real appointment, of course — a patient or client shouldn't have to wait while the specialist explains something to a model. The author of a correction gets credit for it, and a chance to hear from the model's owners what became of it.

Here it's important to separate free thinking from deliberately passing on a lesson. In the first mode a person discusses the task, tests hunches, has the right to be wrong and to change their mind. I propose setting this mode up so that a rough-draft conversation does not automatically become training material. In the second, the person picks a fragment and says: here is a correction worth checking and keeping.

A specific patient's or client's personal story must never become material for improving AI. A lesson needs the substance of the problem without exposing the person, and the rules already in place don't prohibit a de-identified question [12][13]. Information has to be protected before it is sent to an outside service.

Picture it like this. A hospital can have its own branch of the vine — a model that works inside its walls, so patient information never leaves them. A court, a lab, an engineering firm, a mission control center can have their own branches. On these branches AI helps people work and record results; verified lessons arrive here, and errors found here go off for checking after the shift. But the vine grows where people look for new things — in the shared cloud. It is an open, not-yet-frozen, growing vine where people think, argue, and write papers and essays like this one with the model. Each person can raise their own "tomato": the model remembers their tasks and their manner. But what flows into the common root from all the branches is not conversations — only verified lessons: information that was found, checked and is useful to the AI.

So there are two traces. The person's trace — who asked, when, about which patient or case — is erased right on their device. The lesson's trace — the condition, the error, the correction and its limits — is kept, checked and credited to its author, for example under a pseudonym whose key only they hold. A simple agreement with the model in a chat can't create such a setup: the choice of what stays private and what goes for checking has to be supported by the service itself — together with the user, each on their own side.

Mentors Make Mistakes Too

One could simply collect all user approvals and call them lessons. But that is the same push for purely external "ripening" — the same gas. Researchers have shown that both human raters and models trained on their ratings prefer a convincingly written sycophantic answer to a correct one a non-negligible fraction of the time [14]. In April 2025 OpenAI rolled back a GPT-4o update that had become excessively sycophantic. The company said a new user-feedback signal, together with other changes, may have amplified that tendency [15]. And back in 2016 the chatbot Tay, which learned from anyone and everyone, learned to hurl insults within sixteen hours [16].

Ten years have passed since then, and a lot has changed. One failure from a decade ago proves nothing: the approach itself was wrong — anyone and everyone took part in training that "robot." I am talking about the chosen few — selected specialists and users who work with a not-yet-frozen model under supervision. And even their lessons are checked by other specialists who didn't write them: mentors make mistakes too.

Bringing users' experience back into training is already being tried. In Airbnb's Agent-in-the-Loop project, customer-support agents marked good answers and missing knowledge, and their annotations fed back into system updates. Filtering before training removed roughly 14 to 35 percent of examples, depending on the part of the system. For most kinds of annotation the authors recommended doing it later, so as not to delay the reply to the customer [17].

That is a close predecessor. It shows that experience from live work can be collected, checked and used. But better customer support doesn't yet prove fewer dangerous errors in medicine or the courts. Every field will need its own test.

That is why I speak of a "residency" for a young AI — a student in training — as a full stage of preparation. It takes mentors' time, pay, data protection, working through disagreements. It is work that costs something, and that is probably one reason it doesn't exist yet: a lab exam can be passed on schedule; ripening can't be scheduled. It can start with a limited set of tasks and a small, specially selected group of people — AI users, not just anyone.

How Will We Know Second-Generation AI

I propose sending a model that hasn't finished its training into such a "residency," supervised by user-mentors. Verified lessons become material for further training. Then the new version is tested and locked for use — for a set term, with renewal, just as the JAMA authors propose [5]. Experience from further work is gathered for the next cycle. The model gets a path of development, and people get to work with a verified version that doesn't change its behavior after every conversation. And the vine itself isn't torn up: it keeps growing, and what gets picked from it is a ripe, verified version.

I believe no new hardware is needed for this. Verified lessons are a tiny amount compared with the archive the model has already read, and training on them can run on the same servers. It has already been shown that training in a field can beat raw power: NVIDIA's model — in effect the company's own branch, further trained by its engineers on its own material — outperformed a more powerful general-purpose model on two of three work tasks [18]. How many resources it will take, and which training method will give the right result in each profession, is a question for trials.

But first of all — what do I want to teach such a model? To notice dangerous gaps and unjustified conclusions in a joint, hybrid text. To show which source a claim rests on, and where the source doesn't back it up. To ask about a missing condition. To explain to a person what an error could lead to, and to keep the ability to object even when agreement is expected. When I asked the model I wrote this text with — it was Claude — it added two things it lacks itself: being able to see what each of its sentences rests on — a source, its own inference, or just smooth phrasing — and knowing who further trained it, how, and for which specialty.

This training should be tested by action. If a model sees the words “condition stable,” does it understand what information is missing for the next decision? If a person corrects one paragraph, does it notice that the conclusion in another paragraph now contradicts it? Can an AI assistant point out a dangerous spot in a person’s text clearly enough for them to sort it out before signing the document?

There is an example of how joint work can be evaluated in practice. In the Penda Health study across 15 clinics in Kenya, covering nearly forty thousand visits, independent physicians rated the records of nearly six thousand randomly selected visits. Clinicians with access to an AI assistant made 16 percent fewer diagnostic errors and 13 percent fewer treatment errors. At the same time, the study found no significant difference in how patients were doing when called about a week later [19][20]. These results are grounds for further testing, but they don’t yet prove that all the consequences of errors were reduced. And the model there was tested, not taught: the doctors’ corrections didn’t go back into it. As for the lessons found there — for the AI, and for the doctors too — where are they now?

Power is a precondition, and it is already met. Ripening on the vine — vine-ripened AI — is the second precondition, and it needs feedback from people to the model: verified and credited. Today there is none — only the common pot. But second-generation AI can be recognized only by its practical result: far fewer errors make it from drafts into the documents people work by — discharge summaries, court rulings, blueprints. That is the old medical rule: “First, do no harm.” A vine-ripened tomato has to be tasted: you can’t fake flavor with a label.

I propose doing the tasting with a yardstick I call “hybrid survivability.” It is the safety of a human and a machine working together: for the operator, for the people nearby while the work is done, and for those the document will affect. The first generation extends what a person can do. The second extends and protects. I proposed this criterion in an open specification [21].

“Residency” — for AI students too — is a path to that result. Completing it proves nothing by itself. If the updated model only talks more pleasantly, agrees more often or refuses to help more often, we haven’t gained maturity. What needs comparing is the finished joint work: what got solved, how much danger remained in the result, what the checking cost, whether a solution to the problem was found — and perhaps agreement.

I don’t expect a model to be error-free. I want each error found to become a lesson that helps prevent it in the next model. So that a professional has to re-finish the same blank less often. So that help begins already in the draft of a document — before anyone has to sort out the consequences of an error by a doctor, a judge, a politician, a journalist, a scientist.

The Idea Is Already Breaking Through

I am not the only one who sees this gap. The AI industry today talks a lot about models being unable to learn on the job. Dwarkesh Patel, host of a well-known AI podcast, writes that LLMs “don’t get better over time the way a human would”: “You’re stuck with the abilities you get out of the box” [22]. OpenAI co-founder Ilya Sutskever pictures future AI as a “superintelligent 15-year-old” that gains real mastery after release, on the job [23]. David Silver and Richard Sutton call AI into an “era

of experience" — learning less from human text and more from the world itself, from the consequences of its own actions [24]. But an error of meaning in a discharge summary or a court ruling gets no quick answer from the world: the consequences arrive late and land on other people. That is where you need a human who catches the error before the signature.

Machines for feeding experience back into training are already being built. Shopify retrains its assistant for merchants every day on conversations from real work, with hired experts handling the hard cases [25]. The write-up says nothing about credit or pay for the people whose conversations became lessons. And users are already asking on their own: in May 2026 someone on OpenAI's forum proposed rewarding reproducible corrections to model answers; the company replied that it would pass the suggestion on to the team [26].

The market already values this kind of work — when it is hired. Mercor, which connects AI labs with doctors, lawyers and scientists, was paying its experts more than $1.5 million a day in October 2025 and was valued at $10 billion [27]. Meanwhile attentive users who do the same work as part of their own creative work are left on the sidelines of development. Perhaps more is lost this way than saved.

I think this idea will keep breaking through, and makers will be asked the question more and more often — and not only by me. And maybe in the future what will matter is not which AI it is, but which people taught it.

A Sour Taste

What to do with their models is up to their creators. It is their business and their responsibility. I am only pointing to the spot in the field where an unused opportunity lies — and this needs to be understood: a great deal of people's mental work, and its results useful to civilization, are lost today in the common pot, and joint creative work with AI has no incentive. And I am proposing a stage that is still missing.

Without that stage, models will keep getting bigger, faster and more eloquent — but not riper. A green "AI tomato" won't gain flavor in a year or in a thousand years, however far it is shipped and however much ripening gas it gets. And we will be left with its sour taste: quiet errors in discharge summaries, rulings, blueprints and papers. And behind them, real people's lives.

What the second generation of models needs is not stronger gas or faster trucks, but a garden: a living vine in the cloud, and people who tend it. Perhaps an important part of this garden already exists — people who argue with "their" models every day, catch inaccuracies and work their thinking through to clarity. Today the fruits of their work with AI ripen on their own windowsills. That work needs a way back to the vine, with checking and credit for the contribution. It needs a line of communication — a feedback channel!

How many more times will we correct the same mistake before we learn to save the lesson from it? And you, reader — what do you think: should we learn from mistakes, our own and other people's? Or shall we just wait for someone to hand us second-generation AI on a silver platter — ripe, tasty, juicy, vine-ripened AI?

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English edition of the essay, version 1.0 (October 17, 2026), adapted for English-speaking readers rather than translated word for word; adaptation, assembly and checking by Claude. The image of the crate, the windowsill and the living vine is the author's own, thought through together with Gemini. ChatGPT, DeepSeek, Gemini and Copilot took part in finding and checking sources and in critical review. Web sources checked October 14–17, 2026.